unit 8 CD2

Conversation track 22, 24, 25

Gareth and Helena have just heard that their company is restructuring.

Gareth: Well, that was a bombshell, eh? Our whole department's **up in the air**.

Helena: Seriously. And with the merger falling through, we're **back to square one**.

Gareth: Do you reckon they'll **lay people off**?

Helena: They didn't **rule it out**. That's what worries me.

Gareth: Same. If you read between the lines, it's all about cutting costs.

Helena: Probably. Either way, **the ball's in their court** now.

Gareth: True. Still, I might dust off my CV, just in case.

Helena: Smart move. I'm gonna keep my head down and see how it **plays out**.

Gareth: Fancy a coffee? I need to get my head around all this.

Helena: Sure, but no shop talk. My brain's completely fried.

Study Notes

If you read between the lines, it's all about cutting costs.
Đọc kỹ ý tứ thì rốt cuộc là chuyện cắt giảm chi phí.
"read between the lines" = hiểu ý ngầm, điều người ta không nói thẳng ra.
Cách nói tương đương: The hidden agenda is cutting costs.

I need to get my head around all this.
Tôi cần tiêu hoá hết mấy chuyện này đã.
"get your head around something" = hiểu, chấp nhận được một điều phức tạp hoặc bất ngờ.
Cách nói tương đương: I need time to process all this.

Speak Like a Native track 23

1. Well, that was a bombshell, eh?
linking: "was_a"
weak: "was", "a"
strong: "bombshell", "eh"
"eh" cuối câu là nét rất New Zealand, giống "nhỉ": đọc "ây" và lên giọng để tìm sự đồng tình.

2. And with the merger falling through, we're back to square one.
smooth: "back to square one"
weak: "the", "to"
strong: "falling through", "square one"
Ở tốc độ thật, "back to square one" đọc liền một hơi: "bác-tơ-squer-wăn". Giọng Mỹ đọc rõ /r/ trong "merger", "square".

3. Do you reckon they'll lay people off?
smooth: "Do you"
linking: "people_off"
strong: "reckon", "off"
"Do you" lướt thành "đơ-yơ"; "people off" → "pi-pơ-lóf". Giọng New Zealand thường đọc /e/ gần "i": "reckon" nghe như "rí-cần".

• Giọng New Zealand thường đọc /e/ gần "i" (reckon), /æ/ gần "e" (Fancy); cuối câu hay có "eh?" lên giọng.
• Thành ngữ ở tốc độ thật đọc liền như một từ: back to square one, the ball's in their court.
• Phrasal verb đứng cuối câu thường nhấn vào tiểu từ: lay people OFF, rule it OUT, plays OUT.

Grammar Focus

Thành ngữ khi tình hình chưa rõ ràng

up in the air = chưa quyết, chưa rõ; back to square one = quay về vạch xuất phát; the ball's in someone's court = đến lượt ai đó quyết định.

Our holiday plans are still **up in the air**.
The deal collapsed, so it's **back to square one**.
I've made my offer. **The ball's in your court**.

Phrasal verbs trong tin công ty: lay off / rule out / play out

lay off = cho nghỉ việc (vì cắt giảm); rule out = loại trừ một khả năng; play out = diễn biến, xảy ra.

The factory **laid off** two hundred workers.
Doctors haven't **ruled out** surgery.
Let's wait and see how things **play out**.

Role Play track 27

A: Well, that was a bombshell, eh? Our whole department's up in the air.

B: Seriously. And with the merger falling through, we're _____.

A: Do you reckon they'll lay people off?

B: They didn't rule it out. That's what worries me.

A: Same. If you read between the lines, it's all about cutting costs.

B: Probably. Either way, _____ now.

A: True. Still, I might dust off my CV, just in case.

B: Smart move. I'm gonna keep my head down and see how it _____.

A: Fancy a coffee? I need to get my head around all this.

B: Sure, but no shop talk. My brain's completely fried.

Substitution Drill track 28

1. And with the merger falling through, we're back to square one.
   a. starting from scratch
   b. back where we started
   c. in limbo again

2. Either way, the ball's in their court now.
   a. it's out of our hands
   b. it's their call
   c. it's up to management

3. I'm gonna keep my head down and see how it plays out.
   a. pans out
   b. unfolds
   c. shakes out